

Racial Achievement Gaps in Wisconsin Public Schools

Excerpt — Draft (Introduction; Figures 1, 3, 9, 12, and 20)

Jason Fletcher

April 2026

This brief PDF reproduces the Introduction and Figures 1, 3, 9, 12, and 20 from the full main-draft report (same content as the numbered figures in main-draft.pdf). Each figure appears on its own landscape page, scaled to fit.

Introduction

Wisconsin’s racial achievement gap is among the most severe in the nation. On the 2024 National Assessment of Educational Progress (NAEP), Wisconsin posted the largest Black-White gap in fourth-grade reading nationwide, exceeding states historically associated with school segregation such as Louisiana, Mississippi, and South Carolina (Reardon et al. 2019). On the Wisconsin Forward Exam — the state’s primary accountability assessment for grades 3–8 — the Black-White proficiency gap stands at approximately 43 percentage points, with Black students proficient at a rate of 18% compared to 61% for White students (Wisconsin Department of Public Instruction, n.d.).

This paper is motivated by a concrete policy question: the Madison Metropolitan School District (MMSD) is conducting a two-year attendance boundary review (2025–2027) with the stated goal of promoting “socio-economic, linguistic, and racial diversity within and across schools” (Madison Metropolitan School District 2025). To assess the potential impact of boundary changes on racial achievement gaps, we need to know two things: how large is MMSD’s racial gap, and how much of that gap is between schools (and thus potentially addressable by boundary changes) versus within schools (and thus unaffected by student reassignment).

We address these questions with four complementary analyses. First, we document statewide racial proficiency gaps by race, grade, and subject over the primary Forward Exam window (2015–16 to 2022–23, excluding COVID-disrupted years). Second, we decompose the statewide Black-White and Hispanic-White gaps into within- and between-district components using a standard linear decomposition (Reardon et al. 2024). Third, we extend the analysis to grade-11 outcomes using Wisconsin ACT data — which uniquely benefits from near-universal participation due to the state’s mandatory testing policy — documenting an “educational pipeline” comparison of gaps at grades 3–8 versus grade 11. Fourth, we conduct a detailed analysis of MMSD, including: (a) comparing MMSD minority students to same-race peers in peer districts with substantial minority enrollment (Milwaukee, Racine, Kenosha, Green Bay, and others); (b) comparing MMSD minority students to White students in non-MMSD Wisconsin districts, to account for the outlier-SES status of MMSD White students; and (c) decomposing the MMSD gap into within- and between-school components.

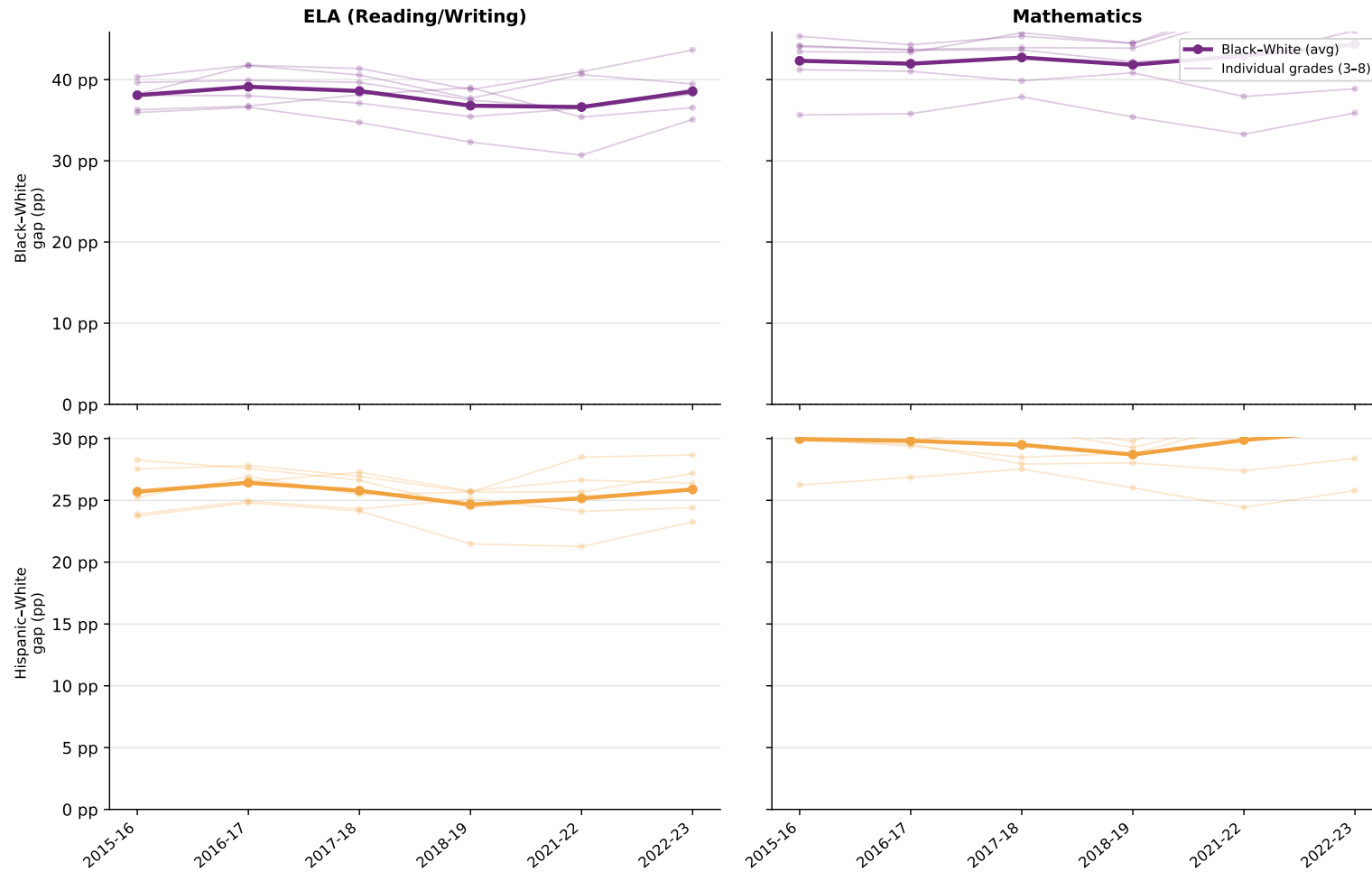
Our main findings are as follows. The statewide BW gap is large (~38–44 pp depending on subject), persistent (no trend toward closure 2015–2023), and approximately equally split between within- and between-district components. Within MMSD, however, the within-school component dominates: 82% of the MMSD BW gap exists within individual schools, and

only 18% is between schools. Perhaps most strikingly, MMSD Black students perform at lower proficiency rates than Black students in Milwaukee and several other peer districts — undermining the common assumption that minority students in MMSD benefit from their district’s overall high reputation.

The paper proceeds as follows. Later sections of the full report review the literature, describe the data and analytical approach, document statewide gaps, present the within-between decomposition, the grade-11 ACT and pipeline analysis, the MMSD-specific analysis, and policy implications in the conclusion.

Figure 1. Statewide racial proficiency gap trends (Forward Exam)

Statewide Racial Proficiency Gaps — Forward Exam (Primary Years 2015-2023)



Note: Thin lines = individual grades 3-8. Bold = grade-enrollment-weighted average.
 Primary years: 2015-16 to 2022-23, excluding 2019-20 (no testing) and 2020-21 (COVID disruption).

Figure 3. Within-between decomposition of racial proficiency gaps (Forward Exam)

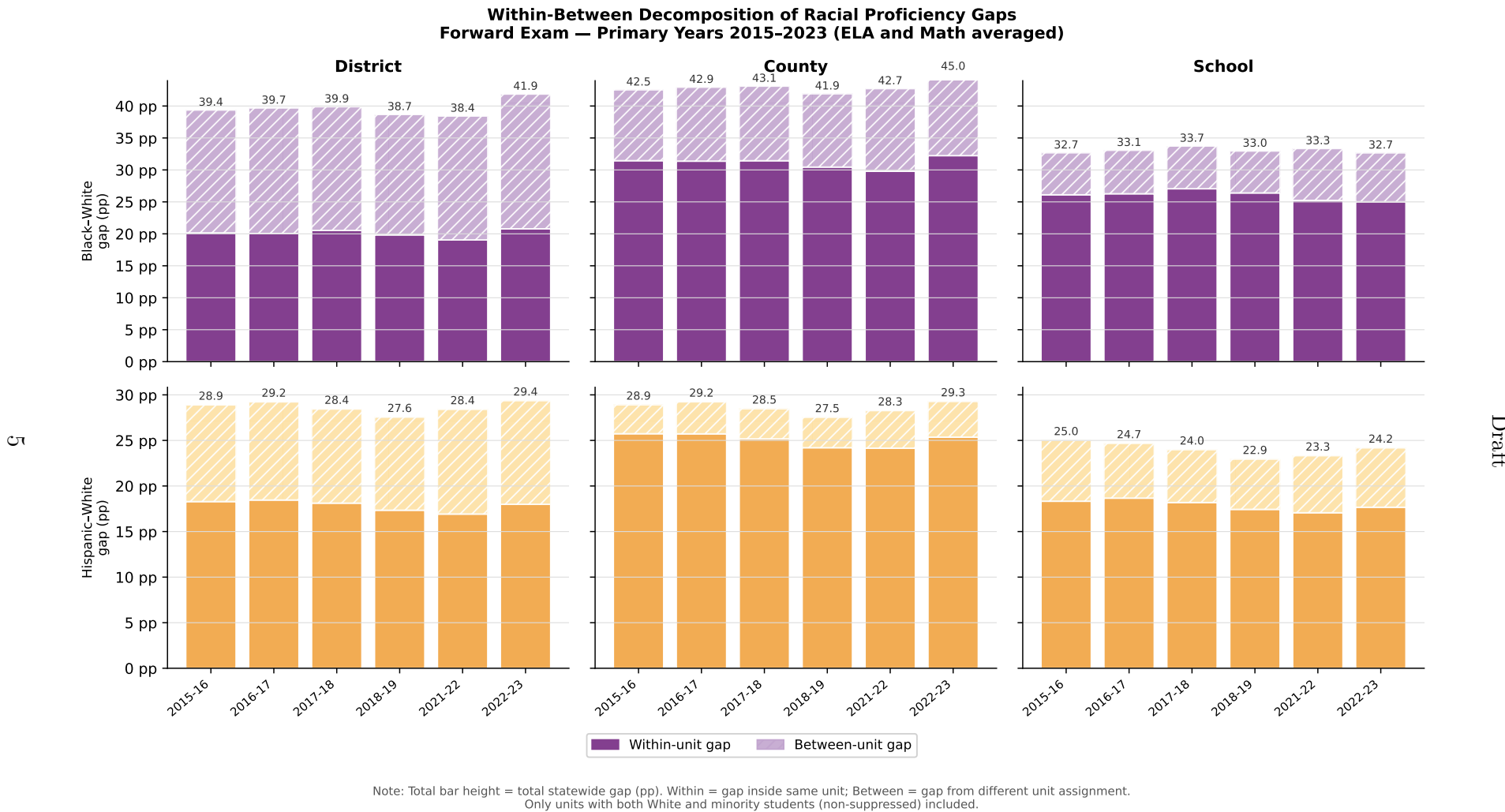


Figure 9. MMSD Black students vs. peer-district Black students

MMSD Black Students vs. Peer Districts — Forward Exam Primary Years

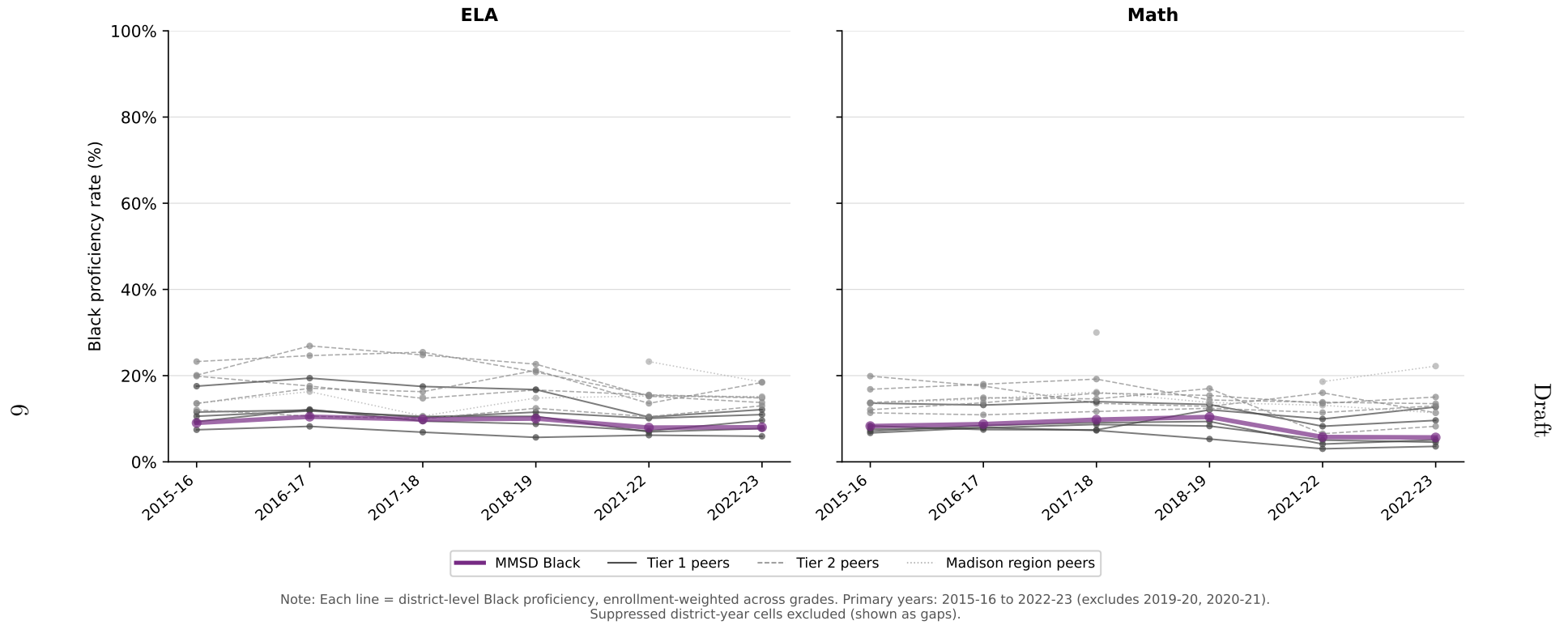
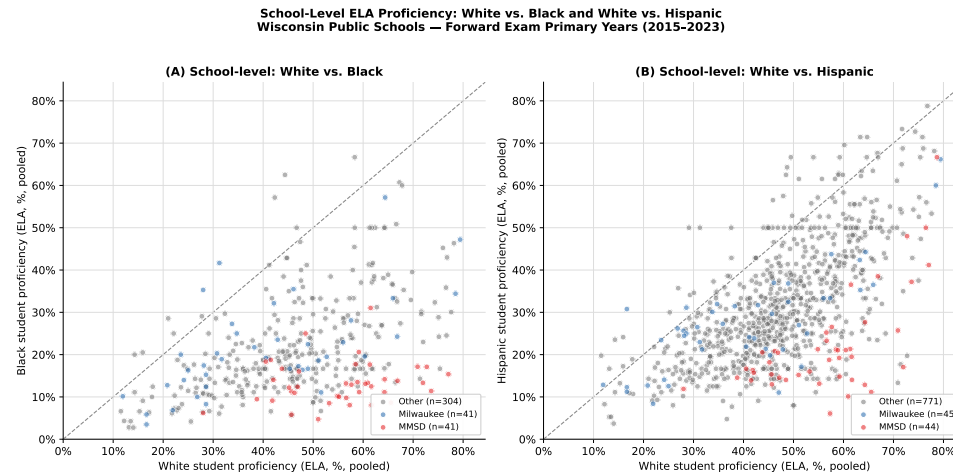


Figure 12. School-level White vs. Black and White vs. Hispanic (ELA)



Note: Each point is one school $\times$ district. Proficiency is enrollment-weighted across grades 3–8 and primary years (excludes 2019–20 and 2020–21). A school appears in a panel only if both proficiency rates are non-suppressed (DPI $n < 10$ rule). Dashed line = parity (no racial gap at the school level). Correlations are Pearson r between horizontal (White) and vertical (Black or Hispanic) axes.

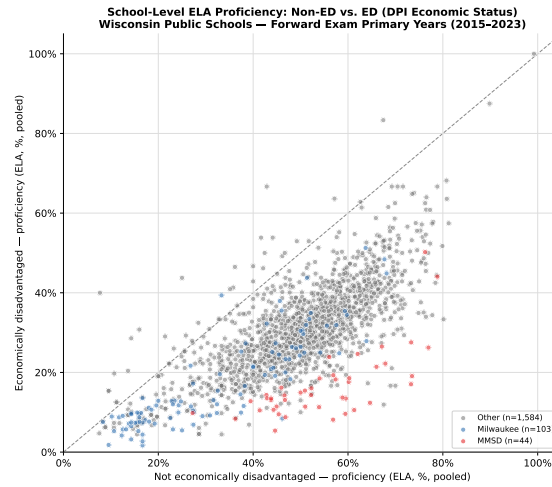
Panel A (White vs. Black):
 (a) Overall $r = 0.458$ ($n = 386$); (b) MMSD $r = 0.177$ ($n = 41$)
 (c) Milwaukee $r = 0.612$ ($n = 41$); (d) Other $r = 0.544$ ($n = 304$)

Panel B (White vs. Hispanic):
 (a) Overall $r = 0.614$ ($n = 860$); (b) MMSD $r = 0.646$ ($n = 44$)
 (c) Milwaukee $r = 0.762$ ($n = 45$); (d) Other $r = 0.650$ ($n = 771$)

Note. Each point is one school $\times$ district. Proficiency is enrollment-weighted across grades 3–8 and primary years (excludes 2019–20 and 2020–21). A school appears in a panel only if both proficiency rates are non-suppressed (DPI $n < 10$ rule). Dashed line = parity (no racial gap at the school level). Correlations are Pearson r between horizontal (White) and vertical (Black or Hispanic) axes.

Panel A (White vs. Black): (a) Overall $r = 0.458$ ($n = 386$); (b) MMSD $r = 0.177$ ($n = 41$); (c) Milwaukee $r = 0.612$ ($n = 41$); (d) Other $r = 0.544$ ($n = 304$). Panel B (White vs. Hispanic): (a) Overall $r = 0.614$ ($n = 860$); (b) MMSD $r = 0.646$ ($n = 44$); (c) Milwaukee $r = 0.762$ ($n = 45$); (d) Other $r = 0.650$ ($n = 771$).

Figure 20. School-level non-ED vs. ED (DPI economic status; Appendix E in full report)



Note: Each point is one school $\times$ district. Proficiency is enrollment-weighted across grades 3–8 and primary years (excludes 2019–20 and 2020–21). A school appears only if both economic-status proficiency rates are non-suppressed. DPI Unknown economic-status cells are excluded. Dashed line = parity (no ED–non-ED gap at the school level). This cut is not nested with race; it describes poverty status, not racial composition.

Pearson correlations (non-ED vs. ED proficiency):
 (a) Overall $r = 0.741$ ($n = 1,731$); (b) MMSD $r = 0.705$ ($n = 44$)
 (c) Milwaukee $r = 0.871$ ($n = 103$); (d) Other $r = 0.737$ ($n = 1,584$)

Note. Each point is one school $\times$ district. Proficiency is enrollment-weighted across grades 3–8 and primary years (excludes 2019–20 and 2020–21). A school appears only if both economic-status proficiency rates are non-suppressed. DPI unknown economic-status cells are excluded. Dashed line = parity (no ED–non-ED gap at the school level). This cut is not nested with race; it describes poverty status, not racial composition.

Pearson r (non-ED vs. ED proficiency): (a) Overall $r = 0.741$ ($n = 1,731$); (b) MMSD $r = 0.705$ ($n = 44$); (c) Milwaukee $r = 0.871$ ($n = 103$); (d) Other $r = 0.737$ ($n = 1,584$).